

THE

CBSE Board Exam 2027 Playbook

Class 10 & Class 12 | Verified Edition

The pattern decoded. The 33% and grading maths explained.
The internal-assessment marks captured. A 137-day plan
from October to February. Subject playbooks for both classes.

Built from official CBSE sources | October 2026

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About this handbook

This is a working handbook for the students who will sit the CBSE board exams in 2027 — and for the parents and teachers standing behind them. It does one job: it turns the official CBSE rulebook into a clear, dated, do-this-today plan.

It is built for the person who is tired of rumour. Every exam date, mark weight, pass rule and fee in these pages was checked against the Central Board of Secondary Education's own notifications, its curriculum and its 2026 result press releases. Where a number is our estimate rather than the Board's own, we say so plainly, on the page.

The handbook covers both Class 10 and Class 12, because the two share one spine — the same 2026-27 question-paper design, the same 50/20/30 question mix, the same grading scale, the same February start. The subject playbooks then split, so you can read the chapters that are yours and skip the rest.

How to use it

- 1 **Read Sections 1 to 3 first.** They are the rules of the game — what is confirmed, how the paper is built, and exactly how you pass. Skipping them is the single most common mistake students make.
- 2 **Then start Section 4 today.** It is a 137-day plan anchored to 2 October 2026 and the expected exam start of 16 February 2027. Print it, put it on the wall, tick it daily.
- 3 **Use your subject chapters as a checklist,** not as a textbook. Each one names what the paper rewards, the marks that move fastest, and the traps that cost marks.
- 4 **Keep Section 7 for later.** Compartment, improvement, the second board exam, verification and re-evaluation — the things you hope you never need, but must understand before you do.

A note on honesty and dates

As of 2 October 2026 the CBSE date sheet for the 2027 board exams had not yet been released. The Board has said it will follow the same pattern as 2025-26, and it has released the 2026-27 sample papers and marking schemes. Every date in this handbook is either the Board's own confirmed date or is clearly labelled as expected, with the reason.

Rules and fees can change. Before you act on any deadline or fee, confirm it on cbse.gov.in and cbseacademic.nic.in. This handbook is an independent guide and is not affiliated with or endorsed by the CBSE.

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At a glance

Exams expected to begin: around Tuesday 16 February 2027 (CBSE's stated rule is the first Tuesday after 15 February).

Class 10 runs twice: Session 1 in February-March, Session 2 in May 2027.

Class 12: a single exam window, expected February to early April 2027.

Date sheet: expected late October 2026. Sample papers and marking schemes are already out.

SECTION 1

The board exam at a glance

Start with what is nailed down

Four things about the 2027 exams are already settled, and they are settled by the Board itself, not by coaching-centre speculation. Knowing them calmly removes most of the anxiety that fills group chats in October.

- **The pattern is unchanged.** In a circular dated 21 September 2026, CBSE confirmed there is **no change in the question-paper design or assessment pattern** for 2026-27, and that the passing criteria stay the same as 2025-26.
- **The sample papers are out.** Subject-wise Sample Question Papers and marking schemes for Classes 10 and 12 for 2026-27 were published on cbseacademic.nic.in on 21 September 2026. These are the closest thing to the real paper you will ever see — use them early.
- **Class 10 still has two board exams.** The two-examination policy (introduced by notification on 25 June 2025) continues: a main exam in February-March and an improvement exam in May.
- **The registration window is closing.** Schools are submitting the List of Candidates (LOC) for the 2027 main exams; the last date for the regular submission window was announced as 21 October 2026.

What is still expected, not confirmed

The date sheet is the one big unknown. CBSE has not released it, and it has not followed a fixed calendar in recent years. Here is the honest picture, so you can plan without pretending you know more than you do.

Year of exam	Date sheet released	Exams began
2023	12 December 2022	February 2023
2024	20 November 2023	February 2024
2025	30 October 2024	15 February 2025
2026	Tentative 24 Sep 2025; final 30 Oct 2025	17 February 2026
2027	Expected late October 2026	Expected around 16 February 2027

Two things make the 16 February 2027 estimate reasonable rather than a guess. First, CBSE's own draft scheme states the rule that Class 10 and Class 12 exams begin on the first Tuesday after 15 February — and 16 February 2027 is a Tuesday. Second, the 2026 exams began on 17 February, the equivalent Tuesday that year. Treat it as a strong planning assumption, not a promise.

The one date that is a hard deadline

The **List of Candidates (LOC)** is the form through which your school registers you for the exam. CBSE's stated deadline for the regular 2026-27 window was **21 October 2026**. If you are a private candidate, the window and fees differ — check the current notice on cbse.gov.in. You cannot sit the exam without the LOC, so confirm with your school this week that your name, subjects and personal details are correct.

The 2026 cycle in numbers

The best guide to what 2027 will feel like is what 2026 actually did. These are the Board's own result figures, and they tell you two useful things: the exam is passable, and the top is crowded.

17.7 lakh Class 12 candidates, 2026 17,68,968 appeared; 15,07,109 passed	85.20% Class 12 pass rate, 2026 Down 3.19 points from 88.39% in 2025	24.7 lakh Class 10 candidates, 2026 24,71,777 appeared across 27,339 schools	93.70% Class 10 pass rate, 2026 Up marginally from 93.66% in 2025
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Class 12, 2026 result	Figure	What it means for you
Scored 90% and above	94,028 (5.32%)	Roughly 1 in 19 candidates clears 90%
Scored 95% and above	17,113 (0.97%)	Roughly 1 in 103 clears 95%
Placed in compartment	1,63,800 (9.26%)	Nearly 1 in 11 must clear a subject later
Top region by pass %	Trivandrum, 95.62%	Region and school support matter

The Class 10 story is quieter but just as revealing. Of the students who took the May 2026 second board exam to improve, 5,13,955 appeared and 3,08,095 — 59.95% — actually raised their score. Of the 1,49,822 who appeared under the compartment category, 78,503 (52.40%) cleared it. After combining both sessions, the Class 10 pass rate rose to 96.78%. That is the two-exam policy doing exactly what it was designed to do.

Your pre-exam checklist

Tick these off before the end of October 2026. Every one of them is your responsibility, not your school's alone.

- **LOC confirmed.** Ask your school to show you the subjects and codes registered in your name. Errors here are painful to fix later.
- **Sample papers downloaded.** Get the 2026-27 SQP and marking scheme for every one of your subjects from cbseacademic.nic.in. Save them offline.
- **Practical and project work planned.** Your internal-assessment marks are earned during the school year, not in February. Know each subject's project, portfolio and lab requirements now.
- **Admit card and exam-centre rules understood.** No communication devices are allowed inside the centre. Know the reporting time — exams run 10:30 am to 1:30 pm IST for three-hour papers.
- **A study space and a tracker.** Section 4 gives you the plan; Section 8 gives you the tracker. Set both up this week.

Who does what

A calm exam season depends on three parties doing their own job. Confusion about roles is where most October stress comes from.

Party	Owns	Do not expect them to
CBSE	The date sheet, the papers, the marking, the results, the post-result process	Register you, or fix your LOC — that runs through your school
Your school	LOC submission, internal assessment, practicals, admit card	Chase you for assignments — the 20 internal marks are yours to lose
You	Preparation, internal-assessment work, checking your own details, sitting the paper	Wait for a forwarded message to tell you the dates

The three official websites

- **cbse.gov.in** — the Board's home: circulars, the date sheet, admit-card and result links, post-result notices.
- **cbseacademic.nic.in** — the academic portal: the 2026-27 syllabus, Sample Question Papers and marking schemes.
- **results.digilocker.gov.in** — where results and digital marksheets are delivered.

Everything else — coaching-centre posters, WhatsApp forwards, 'leaked' timetables — is noise. When a date matters, it appears on one of those three sites first.

What changed from 2025 to 2026

Tracking what the Board changed last year is the best way to guess what it will not surprise you with this year.

Change introduced for 2026	Status for 2027
Two board exams for Class 10	Continues
On-screen marking of Class 12 answer books	Continues
Sample papers and marking schemes released early	Repeated — out since 21 September 2026
A proposed stricter Class 10 pass rule	Withdrawn for 2026-27
Two levels of Class 10 Mathematics	Continues (Standard 041 and Basic 241)

SECTION 2

The paper, decoded

Every board paper for 2026-27 is built to one blueprint: a mix of easy objective marks, applied case-based marks, and a smaller set of long answers. Understand the blueprint and you stop studying everything equally — which is how toppers get 95% and hard workers get 75%.

Class 10: the 80 + 20 paper

Every major Class 10 subject is marked out of 100, split into an 80-mark theory paper set and marked by the Board, and 20 marks of internal assessment marked by your school. The theory paper is three hours long and has five sections, A to E.

Section	Question type	Marks each	Count	Total
A	Objective / MCQ and assertion-reason	1	20	20
B	Very short answer	2	5	10
C	Short answer	3	6	18
D	Long answer	5	4	20
E	Case-based / source-based	4	3	12
	Theory total		38	80

The five compulsory subjects are Mathematics, Science, Social Science, English and Hindi (or another language). Mathematics is offered at two levels — Standard (code 041) and Basic (code 241) — with the same paper structure but different difficulty. Note the practical consequence: a student who takes Basic Mathematics cannot take Mathematics in Class 11, so choose the level with your Class 11 plans in mind.

Class 10 marks at a glance

The 80+20 split is common to almost every Class 10 subject. A few subjects, such as the skill electives and music, follow a different weight, but for the five core subjects this is the map.

Subject	Code	Theory	Internal	Total
Hindi Course A / B	002 / 085	80	20	100
English (Language and Literature)	184	80	20	100
Mathematics (Standard)	041	80	20	100
Mathematics (Basic)	241	80	20	100
Science	086	80	20	100
Social Science	087	80	20	100

Class 12: the 70 + 30 and 80 + 20 papers

Class 12 subjects carry 100 marks each, but the split differs by subject. Science subjects and a few others give 30 marks to practical work; most others give 20 marks to internal assessment.

Subject group	Theory	Practical / Internal	Examples
Science and lab-based	70	30	Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Computer Science, Geography
Non-lab subjects	80	20	Mathematics, English, Economics, Business Studies, Accountancy, History, Political Science, Sociology, Hindi

CBSE offers around 120 subjects at the Class 12 level — the widest choice of any national or international board — and its exams run in about 27 countries, always at Indian Standard Time. Whatever your combination, the paper design below applies.

Class 12 marks at a glance

Two clusters, one rule: 100 marks per subject, split between a written paper and practical or internal work. Confirm your own subject's split on the marking scheme before you build a revision plan around it.

Subject	Theory	Practical / Internal	Cluster
Physics	70	30	Science
Chemistry	70	30	Science
Biology	70	30	Science
Computer Science	70	30	Science
Mathematics	80	20	Non-lab
Accountancy	80	20	Non-lab
Business Studies	80	20	Non-lab
Economics	80	20	Non-lab
English Core	80	20	Non-lab
Political Science	80	20	Non-lab

The 50 / 20 / 30 question mix

This is the single most important table in the handbook, because it tells you where the marks are. Roughly half of every theory paper now tests application, not memory.

Share of paper	What it tests	What you must practise
About 50%	Competency-based: case studies, source-based, data-based, application MCQs	Reading a passage or data set and applying a concept — not reciting definitions
About 20%	Objective / multiple-choice	Speed, accuracy and the ability to eliminate wrong options
About 30%	Short and long answers	Structure, keywords, diagrams and step-by-step working

Two facts that save you marks

There is no negative marking in CBSE board papers. Never leave an objective question blank — an educated guess costs nothing and can gain a mark.

Internal choices exist in the long-answer sections of most papers, but there is no overall choice. Practise choosing fast and committing, because deciding under pressure eats minutes you cannot get back.

How a case-based question actually works

A 4-mark case-based question usually gives a short situation — a graph, a paragraph or a table — and then asks two or three sub-questions of 1, 1 and 2 marks. Here is the pattern to copy.

Sub-question	Marks	What the examiner wants
Identify / state	1	A single precise term or value, lifted from the situation
Explain why	1	One correct reason, in one clear sentence
Apply / calculate / justify	2	A short worked step or a two-point argument, not a paragraph

Notice what is absent: no definition is asked for. Students lose these marks by writing the textbook definition they memorised instead of answering the question in front of them. Read the situation twice, underline the command word, then answer exactly what is asked.

The 20 internal-assessment marks you fully control

Class 10's 20 internal marks are not one exam. They are four small blocks of 5 marks each, awarded by your school across the year. Most students lose 4 to 8 marks here through sheer neglect — marks that were never on the board paper at all.

Block	Marks	How it is earned
Periodic assessment	5	Best of your periodic / pre-board written tests
Multiple assessment	5	Quizzes, oral tests, concept maps, short assignments
Portfolio	5	Classwork, notebook neatness, project record, achievements
Subject enrichment	5	Lab work in Science, map work in Social Science, ASL in languages

Treat these as 20 free marks that the syllabus does not cover. Submit every assignment, keep the notebook clean, and attend the lab and ASL sessions. This is the cheapest 20 marks in the entire exam.

An internal-assessment action plan

When	Action	Why it pays
This month	Ask each teacher exactly what will be assessed in each of the four blocks	Removes surprises in the final term
Every week	Submit every assignment on time and keep the notebook current	Portfolio marks are decided on consistency, not brilliance
Before each periodic test	Revise for it as if it were a board paper	The best of your tests is counted
Before lab / ASL sessions	Know the theory behind the activity	Subject enrichment rewards understanding, not attendance

Class 12 practicals: the 30 marks

For Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Computer Science and similar subjects, the 30 practical marks break into a hands-on experiment or two, a viva, a project or activity record, and the practical file. The examiner is usually external, and the marks are awarded on the day. Three habits decide this score: know the theory behind each experiment, keep an honest and complete record, and be able to explain your work out loud in the viva.

The syllabus, subject by subject

You do not need this handbook to teach you the syllabus — the Board's own curriculum does that. What follows is a map of where each subject's weight sits, so you know which units to build first. Always confirm the detail against the 2026-27 syllabus on cbseacademic.nic.in.

Subject	Where the weight sits
Class 10 Mathematics	Algebra, trigonometry, geometry and coordinate geometry carry the largest blocks; statistics and probability are compact and easy to secure
Class 10 Science	Physics (light, electricity, magnetic effects), Chemistry (carbon compounds, acids and bases, metals) and Biology (life processes, control and coordination, heredity)
Class 10 Social Science	History, Geography, Political Science and Economics, plus a dedicated map-skill question
Class 12 Physics	Electrostatics, current electricity, magnetism, optics and modern physics dominate the numerical and derivation marks
Class 12 Chemistry	Physical chemistry numericals, inorganic trends and reactions, and organic reaction mechanisms with conditions
Class 12 Biology	Genetics, evolution, reproduction, ecology and biotechnology carry the reasoning-heavy marks
Class 12 Accountancy	Partnership accounts, company accounts and analysis of financial statements are the recurring cores
Class 12 Business Studies and Economics	Management, marketing and business environment; macro and microeconomics with Indian policy examples

SECTION 3

The marking system

This section is short and it is decisive. Most of what people repeat about board marking is wrong — especially about the 33% rule, which changed and then changed back for 2026-27.

How you pass: the 33% rules

The qualifying mark in every subject is 33%. But how that 33% is applied differs between the two classes, and the difference matters.

	Class 10 (2026-27)	Class 12
The 33% test	33% aggregate in each subject, with theory and internal assessment added together	33% in each subject
Subjects with practicals	Same aggregate rule — no separate theory/practical threshold	Must also score 33% in theory AND 33% in practical, separately
Internal assessment	Must score above grade E in all internal-assessment subjects	Must score above grade E in all internal-assessment subjects
Divisions or distinction	None awarded	None awarded

The 2026-27 change you should know about

For a while, CBSE's 2026-27 curriculum proposed a stricter Class 10 rule: 33% separately in the board paper and in internal assessment. The Board then withdrew it. In its 21 September 2026 circular it confirmed that the passing criteria stay the same as 2025-26, and the Controller of Examinations restated the position in a webinar on 29 September 2026.

What this means in plain words

For the 2027 Class 10 exam, you need **33% overall in each subject, adding your theory and internal marks together**. Strong internal-assessment marks can carry a weak paper, and vice versa. Do not treat theory and internal marks as two separate walls.

The stricter rule could return for 2027-28, so do not build a habit of relying on it. But for the exam you are sitting, the aggregate rule stands.

The pass calculation, worked out

Two worked examples remove the guesswork.

Student	Theory	Internal	Total	Result
Class 10, Science	18 of 80	18 of 20	36 of 100	Pass — above 33
Class 10, Science	16 of 80	14 of 20	30 of 100	Fail — compartment
Class 12, Physics	25 of 70 (36%)	12 of 30 (40%)	37 of 100	Pass — theory and practical each above 33%

In the Class 10 rows, theory and internal marks are added together, so a strong internal score can lift a weak paper. In the Class 12 Physics row, both the theory and the practical must separately clear 33% — a brilliant practical cannot rescue a theory paper below the line.

Grades, CGPA and percentage

CBSE does not print an overall percentage on your marksheet — it avoids encouraging a race for aggregate totals. It gives grades instead, using a nine-point scale for external subjects and a five-point scale (A to E) for Class 10 internal assessment. Grades are assigned on a rank basis: passed students are placed in order and split into eight equal groups.

Marks range	Grade	Grade point	Meaning
91 - 100	A1	10.0	Top eighth of passed candidates
81 - 90	A2	9.0	Next eighth
71 - 80	B1	8.0	Next eighth
61 - 70	B2	7.0	Next eighth
51 - 60	C1	6.0	Next eighth
41 - 50	C2	5.0	Next eighth
33 - 40	D1	4.0	Next eighth
21 - 32	D2	3.0	Compartment eligible
0 - 20	E	0.0	Essential Repeat

To convert grades into a percentage for college applications, add the grade points of your five best subjects, divide by 5 to get your CGPA, then multiply by 9.5. A CGPA of 9.0 becomes an indicative 85.5%. This multiplier is a convention for an indicative figure, not a mark the Board prints.

Where students actually lose marks

Marks are lost in four predictable places. Fixing these is worth more than any extra hour of revision.

- Presentation and structure.** Long answers that are one dense block score less than the same content broken into labelled points. Use headings, numbered steps and a final line that answers the question asked.
- Diagrams and units.** In Science and Mathematics, an unlabelled diagram or a missing unit loses marks even when the logic is right. Draw, label, and always write the unit.
- Not attempting.** With no negative marking, blank objective questions are pure waste. Attempt everything, even at a guess.
- Misreading the question.** Case-based questions often ask you to apply a concept to a situation. Students who answer with a memorised definition score near zero. Read twice, underline the command word, then answer.

How a 5-mark answer earns its marks

Take a typical 5-mark question: 'Explain the process and state two of its applications.' The marking scheme usually divides it as one mark for naming, two for the explanation and two for the applications. Written as a wall of text, that answer invites the examiner to hunt for the points — and some get missed. Written as a short lead-in, a labelled process and two numbered applications, every mark is visible.

- Open with a one-line answer that names the process.
- Give the explanation in a numbered sequence, not a paragraph.

- List the applications separately, one per line.
- Close with a short line only if it adds something — otherwise stop.

A worked answer: one question, written two ways

Question: 'A student connects a bulb to a battery and notices the bulb glows dimly. State the reason and suggest one way to make it glow brighter.' (3 marks).

Weak answer (1 of 3)	Strong answer (3 of 3)
'The bulb is dim because the current is low. Use a bigger battery.'	Reason: the current through the bulb is small, so it dissipates less power (1 mark). Way: increase the potential difference, use a battery of higher voltage, or reduce the resistance of the circuit (2 marks).

Both students understood the physics. The first lost two marks on precision and presentation; the second made every mark visible. Across a whole paper, that difference compounds into 10 to 15 marks.

SECTION 4

The 137-day plan: 2 October 2026 to 16 February 2027

This is the plan the rest of the handbook points to. It assumes your exams begin around 16 February 2027 and gives you 137 days from today. If the date sheet shifts by a week or two, stretch or compress Phase 3 — the shape stays the same.

The plan on one page

Phase	Dates	Job	Hours a day
Phase 1: Build	Oct to mid-Nov	Finish the syllabus for the first time; start the notebook of formulas and definitions	3 to 4
Phase 2: Practice	mid-Nov to mid-Jan	Convert knowledge into marks: chapter tests, first full mocks, error log	4 to 5
Phase 3: Peak	mid-Jan to 15 Feb	Full papers under timed conditions, revision from your own notes, no new topics	5 to 6

Three rules hold the whole plan together, and they matter more than the hours.

The three rules

The 3:1 rule. For every three hours of new study, spend one hour testing yourself on what you already studied. Study without testing is study you will forget.

The error log. One notebook. Every mistake you make in any test goes in it with the reason. You revise the error log, not the textbook, in the last two weeks.

One paper a week, always timed. From Phase 2 onwards, sit at least one full paper a week at 10:30 am, three hours, no phone. Exam skill is a muscle.

The dated calendar

These are indicative weekly blocks, not a straitjacket. If your syllabus runs faster or slower, move the blocks; keep the order.

Block	Dates	Focus
W1	2 - 8 Oct	Download SQPs; build trackers; list untouched chapters
W2	9 - 15 Oct	Finish the hardest untouched chapters; first summaries
W3	16 - 22 Oct	Continue syllabus; confirm LOC with school
W4	23 - 29 Oct	Continue syllabus; weekly Sunday self-test begins
W5	30 Oct - 5 Nov	Continue syllabus; start the error log
W6	6 - 12 Nov	Close Phase 1; every chapter read once
W7	13 - 19 Nov	Start Phase 2; SQP section-wise practice
W8	20 - 26 Nov	Chapter tests; add PYQs by chapter
W9	27 Nov - 3 Dec	First full mock; mark and log it
W10	4 - 10 Dec	Rebuild the weakest two chapters

Block	Dates	Focus
W11	11 - 17 Dec	Full paper; case-based drills
W12	18 - 24 Dec	Full paper; revise summaries
W13	25 - 31 Dec	Full paper; error-log revision
W14	1 - 7 Jan	Full paper; board-pattern writing practice
W15	8 - 14 Jan	Full paper; close remaining gaps
W16	15 - 21 Jan	Enter Phase 3; two papers a week begins
W17	22 - 28 Jan	Timed papers at 10:30 am; revise from notes only
W18	29 Jan - 4 Feb	Timed papers; rebuild weak three chapters
W19	5 - 11 Feb	Light revision; protect sleep
W20	12 - 16 Feb	Taper; exam-day rehearsal; sit the paper

Phase 1: Build (October to mid-November)

The goal is simple and unglamorous: finish the syllabus once, properly, and build the two assets that will carry you later — your own condensed notes and your error log. Do not chase full papers yet; you do not have the coverage.

- **Week 1 (2-8 Oct):** Download all your sample papers. Set up your tracker (Section 8). Write out each subject's syllabus chapter list and mark the ones you have not touched.
- **Weeks 2-6:** Cover the unfinished chapters, hardest first. After each chapter, write a half-page summary in your own words. This summary is what you will revise in February.
- **Every Sunday:** a 90-minute self-test on the week's chapters — 20 objective and 5 short-answer questions you write yourself from the chapter-end exercises.
- **End of Phase 1 checkpoint:** every chapter at least once, every subject summarised, error log started. If a subject is still untouched, drop a hobby for two weeks and catch up.

Phase 2: Practice (mid-November to mid-January)

Now the shift happens. You stop learning new content and start learning to score. This is where most students' marks are actually made, because the board paper rewards application, and application only improves through practice.

- 1 Do the official 2026-27 sample papers one section at a time first — objective, then case-based, then long answers — before attempting full papers.
- 2 Add previous-year questions. Solve the last five years' papers by chapter so you see which topics repeat.
- 3 Sit your first full mock in the last week of November. Expect it to feel bad. The point is the data, not the score.
- 4 Move to one full timed paper a week. Mark it yourself against the official marking scheme, and record every lost mark in the error log.
- 5 Run a weekly review: which chapters cost you the most marks, and why — knowledge gap, or presentation gap?

Phase 3: Peak (mid-January to 15 February)

No new topics. This phase is about converting what you have into reliable marks under exam conditions, and protecting your energy.

- **Full papers, twice a week**, at the real time — 10:30 am to 1:30 pm. Simulate the reporting time, the silence, the no-phone rule.
- **Revise from your own notes and error log**, not the textbook. You have already read the textbook; now you are rehearsing.
- **Rebuild your weak three chapters** from scratch if the mock data says they keep failing you.
- **Taper in the final five days**. Light revision, sleep at a fixed time, no new material, no all-nighters. A rested brain out-scores a crammed one every time.

The weekly rhythm

A week that works, once Phase 2 is running. Adjust the hours to your reality, but keep the shape — a mix of new work, practice, testing and rest beats a flat grind.

Day	Focus	Notes
Mon	Hardest subject, new or weak chapters	Study when your energy peaks
Tue	Second subject + 30 min self-test	Log every mistake
Wed	Third subject + short-answer practice	Write full answers, not points
Thu	Fourth subject + case-based questions	Practise the 50% block
Fri	Revision from your own notes	No new topics on Friday
Sat	Chapter test, timed	Mark it the same day
Sun	One full paper OR full rest	Rest is part of the plan

A sample study day

Time	Block	Note
06:30 - 08:00	Hardest subject, fresh mind	New or weak chapters
08:00 - 09:00	Breakfast and rest	Protect this; it is not study time
09:00 - 11:30	Second subject	Practice questions, not reading
11:30 - 13:00	Short-answer writing	Write full answers on paper
13:00 - 15:00	Lunch and rest	A short nap improves recall
15:00 - 17:30	Third subject	Case-based and numerical practice
17:30 - 18:30	Movement / exercise	Non-negotiable for stamina
18:30 - 20:30	Revision from notes	No new material
20:30 - 21:30	Self-test + error log	Fifteen minutes of testing
22:00	Sleep	Fixed time, every night

Revision techniques that actually work

Most students revise by re-reading. It feels productive and it barely works. Four techniques give a much better return, and all four fit the plan above.

Technique	How to do it	Why it works
Active recall	Close the book, write down everything you remember, then check	Retrieval builds memory far more than re-reading
Spaced repetition	Revisit a chapter after one day, one week, then one month	Beats forgetting at the exact moments it would happen
Self-explanation	Explain the topic out loud as if teaching a friend	Exposes gaps you did not know you had
Interleaving	Mix questions from different chapters in one sitting	Matches how the real paper mixes topics

The last 30 days, hour by hour

Window	Job	Rule
Day 30 to 21	One full paper every alternate day, timed at 10:30 am	Mark it the same day; log every lost mark
Day 20 to 11	Rebuild the three chapters the mocks keep exposing	Understand them, do not memorise them
Day 10 to 4	Revision only, from your own notes and the error log	No new topics from here
Day 3 to 1	Light skim, logistics checked, sleep protected	Sleep beats cramming every single time

SECTION 5

Class 10 subject playbooks

Each playbook below names the same three things: what the paper rewards, the marks that move fastest, and the traps that quietly cost you. Use them as a checklist against your own preparation.

How to use a marking scheme

Before you practise any subject, open its marking scheme from cbseacademic.nic.in and read it like a rulebook. It tells you, question by question, how marks are split. Three patterns repeat across almost every subject.

What the scheme says	What it means for how you write
'1 mark for the formula, 1 for substitution'	Always show the formula line before you compute
'2 marks for any two points'	Write exactly two clear points, not a paragraph
'1 mark for the labelled diagram'	Never draw a diagram without labels

Mathematics (Standard 041 / Basic 241)

What the paper rewards: correct method, shown step by step. Mathematics is marked by steps, so a wrong final answer with the right working still earns most of the marks. The paper is 80 marks across five sections, and case-based questions worth 4 marks each are where application is tested.

- **Fastest marks:** the 20 objective questions (Section A). Drill mental arithmetic and formula recall so these cost you seconds, not minutes.
- **Structure:** one question per page where possible, every step on its own line, the final answer boxed with its unit.
- **Trap:** rushing Section A and losing easy marks, then running short in Section D's long answers. Budget your time per section.
- **Practice:** solve full papers with a clock; keep a separate notebook of every formula used in a wrong answer.

Science (code 086)

What the paper rewards: concepts explained clearly, plus diagrams, equations and the ability to interpret experiments. Science mixes Physics, Chemistry and Biology, and the 12 case-based marks often come from real-world situations.

- **Fastest marks:** definitions and direct-recall questions, plus fully labelled diagrams — a diagram is usually worth 1 to 2 marks and takes a minute.
- **Equations:** in Physics, write the formula, substitute values, then compute. Skipping the formula step loses marks even with the right number.
- **Trap:** memorising without understanding the application. A definition you cannot apply to a case study scores zero on half the paper.
- **Practice:** for every experiment in the syllabus, be able to state the aim, the observation and the conclusion.

Social Science (code 087)

What the paper rewards: precise, well-organised answers across History, Geography, Political Science and Economics, plus map work. The map-skill question alone is worth 5 marks and is often the easiest five in the paper.

- **Fastest marks:** the map question and the objective section — both are pure preparation with no ambiguity.
- **Structure:** answer in points with a heading, and add dates and names in History where relevant.
- **Trap:** long, unstructured essays that bury the answer. The examiner is looking for specific points.
- **Practice:** practise map marking with a physical outline map weekly until it is automatic.

English (Language and Literature)

What the paper rewards: reading comprehension, writing in the correct format, and literature answers that quote the text. The paper is 80 marks plus 20 internal, with sections for reading, writing and literature.

- **Fastest marks:** the writing section, once you have memorised the formats — notice, letter, article, speech. Format alone is worth marks.
- **Literature:** answer with evidence. A short quotation plus an explanation scores better than a general opinion.
- **Trap:** spending too long on the first reading passage. Time the sections in every practice paper.
- **Practice:** write one full writing-section answer a week, timed, and self-check the format.

Hindi and second languages

What the paper rewards: grammar accuracy, structured writing and comprehension. Language papers are among the most predictable in the board exam, which means they are among the easiest to score highly in with steady practice.

- **Fastest marks:** grammar and comprehension — both reward regular short practice far more than last-minute cramming.
- **Writing:** learn the fixed formats (letter, article, report) and the standard opening and closing lines.
- **Trap:** neglecting the language paper because it feels easy, then losing 10 to 15 marks on avoidable grammar slips.
- **Practice:** ten minutes of grammar a day beats two hours the night before.

SECTION 6

Class 12 subject playbooks

The Class 12 paper is 70 marks of theory plus 30 practical in the science subjects, and 80 plus 20 in the rest. Roughly half of each theory paper is competency-based, so the playbook in every subject is the same at its core: understand, then apply, then practise under time.

Two habits that lift theory marks

- **Write to the mark value.** A 3-mark answer is three points; a 5-mark answer is a short structure with a lead-in, the body and a closing line. Padding wastes time; under-writing loses marks.
- **Use the exact syllabus term.** Examiners look for the precise word from the syllabus. A close synonym often scores less than the exact term.

Physics

- **What the paper rewards:** correct formulae, derivations, numerical accuracy and labelled diagrams. Theory is 70 marks; practicals are 30.
- **Fastest marks:** the objective and very-short-answer questions, and the practical exam's viva if you understand the experiments.
- **Trap:** skipping units and directions in numericals. Marks are deducted even when the value is right.
- **Practice:** keep a single sheet of all formulae per unit and revise it daily in the final month.

Chemistry

- **What the paper rewards:** reactions with correct conditions, structures, and named reasoning. Organic chemistry rewards pattern recognition.
- **Fastest marks:** named reactions and definition-based questions; they are the most predictable part of the paper.
- **Trap:** writing a product without the reagent and condition. Half the mark is usually in the 'how'.
- **Practice:** build a reaction map per chapter; redraw it from memory weekly.

Mathematics

- **What the paper rewards:** method and steps, exactly as in Class 10. Theory is 80 marks plus 20 internal.
- **Fastest marks:** the objective section and the direct formula-application questions.
- **Trap:** leaving a long answer half-finished. Partial working earns partial marks — never leave a blank page.
- **Practice:** solve one full paper a week with a strict time budget per section.

Biology

- **What the paper rewards:** precise terminology, labelled diagrams and reasoning about processes. Theory 70, practical 30.
- **Fastest marks:** definitions, labelled diagrams and process-flow questions.
- **Trap:** vague language. In Biology, the exact term matters more than a near-synonym.

- **Practice:** for each process, be able to draw the diagram and explain it in five sentences.

Accountancy

- **What the paper rewards:** correct formats, workings and totals. Theory 80, internal 20.
- **Fastest marks:** objective questions and the well-practised formats — journal, ledger, balance sheet, cash flow.
- **Trap:** a single arithmetic slip cascading through a long problem. Show workings so you earn method marks.
- **Practice:** do full problems by hand, not by eye; the hand remembers formats.

Business Studies and Economics

- **What the paper rewards:** structured answers with headings, real examples and correct terminology.
- **Fastest marks:** definition and one-line-answer questions, and case-based questions once you know the concepts.
- **Trap:** writing long, unstructured answers. Point-wise answers score more than paragraphs.
- **Practice:** for every concept, memorise one Indian business or policy example to cite.

English Core

- **What the paper rewards:** reading comprehension, writing in format, and literature answers with textual support. Theory 80, internal 20.
- **Fastest marks:** the writing section, once formats are automatic, and the objective literature questions.
- **Trap:** poor time allocation across reading, writing and literature. Practise the split until it is second nature.
- **Practice:** one full writing-section answer and one literature answer a week, timed.

SECTION 7

Exam day and after

The last seven days

- **Days 7 to 4:** revise from your own notes and error log. Re-do your three weakest chapters' summaries. No new topics.
- **Days 3 to 2:** light revision only. Check your admit card, exam centre route and reporting time. Pack your pens, board-approved stationery and admit card the night before.
- **Day 1 (the eve):** stop studying by early evening. Sleep at your normal time. A full night's sleep is worth more than any revision you could cram.
- **Each morning:** a light 30-minute skim of the day's subject, then leave early. Arrive calm, not rushed.

What to carry and what to expect

Carry	Leave behind
Your admit card and school ID	Any phone, smart watch or communication device
Blue or black ballpoint pens, a spare, pencil, eraser, ruler	Notes, textbooks or loose paper
A transparent water bottle if permitted	Anything that makes noise or needs charging
For drawing subjects, your board-approved instruments	Friends' reassurance — you have prepared for this

Reporting time is earlier than the 10:30 am start, so read your admit card carefully. Reach the centre early, sit where you are told, and read the whole paper before you write a word.

Exam-hall rules worth memorising

Papers run **10:30 am to 1:30 pm** for three-hour subjects; two-and-a-half-hour papers end at 1:00 pm. Reporting time is earlier — check your admit card.

No communication devices of any kind are allowed inside the centre. Carry your admit card and follow every instruction on it.

Read the full paper in the first 10 minutes. Mark the questions you will attempt and the ones with internal choice before you write anything.

Exam-day execution

The three hours are a skill you can rehearse. This is the sequence that works.

- 1 Read the whole paper once. Note the sections, the marks per question and the internal choices. Two minutes here saves ten later.
- 2 Attempt Section A (objective) first — fast and certain. With no negative marking, answer every one.
- 3 Move through the short answers next, writing to the mark value: a 2-mark answer needs two clear points, not a paragraph.
- 4 Leave the long answers and case studies for when you are warmed up, and give each its full time.
- 5 Keep the last ten minutes to check that every question is numbered, every diagram is labelled, and every unit is written.

Sleep, stress and the final month

The last month is won or lost on energy as much as knowledge. A tired brain makes the errors that cost marks: misread questions, arithmetic slips, missed pages.

- **Sleep is study.** Seven to eight hours a night consolidates what you learned. An all-nighter trades tomorrow's recall for tonight's comfort.
- **Keep a fixed wake-up time,** even on holidays, so your body is ready for a 10:30 am exam.
- **Move daily.** Twenty minutes of walking or sport lowers stress and improves focus.
- **Protect one rest evening a week.** Burnout in January is the quiet killer of February scores.
- **Talk to someone.** If anxiety is affecting sleep or eating, tell a parent, teacher or counsellor early. This is a normal, fixable thing, not a weakness.

The Class 10 two-exam decision

From 2026, Class 10 students sit a main exam in February-March and an optional second exam in May. The better of the two performances counts. This is genuinely useful, but it is not a reason to treat the first paper as a trial.

- **It is mandatory to appear in the first exam.** The second exam is an opportunity, not a replacement.
- **You can improve up to three main subjects** out of Science, Mathematics, Social Science and languages — and improvement is theory only.
- **You must have appeared in at least three subjects** in the first exam to be eligible for the second. Missing three or more places you in the 'Essential Repeat' category instead.
- **The second exam is also the compartment route** for students who did not clear a subject, and it acts as the supplementary exam.
- **Plan as if there is one exam.** Students who rely on the second paper usually end up needing it.

What comes next: Class 11 and beyond

A board result opens doors but does not choose the corridor. A few facts are worth holding before you decide.

- **After Class 10:** you choose a stream — Science, Commerce, Arts, or a vocational path. Class 10 Basic Mathematics closes the door to Mathematics in Class 11, so make that choice deliberately.
- **After Class 12:** your next step depends on the stream and your entrance exams — engineering, medicine, law, management, design, defence, civil services, or a degree with a skill on the side. Start the entrance-exam conversation in Class 11, not after the board result.
- **The board score is a floor, not a ceiling.** It qualifies you; your entrance exam, portfolio or skills decide the seat.

Compartment, improvement and the second board exam

If the result is not what you hoped, the Board gives you a defined path back. Knowing it in advance removes the panic.

Route	Who it is for	Key rule
Compartment (Class 10)	Failed in up to two of the five subjects	Reappear in the compartment exam; three chances (Jul/Aug, then Mar/Apr, then Jul/Aug)

Route	Who it is for	Key rule
Compartment (Class 12)	Failed in one of the five subjects	Same three-chance structure
Class 10 second board exam	Passed students who want to improve	Improve up to three main subjects (theory only); the better of the two scores counts
Improvement (next year)	Passed students wanting better marks	One chance only, in the main exam of the succeeding year; practical marks carried forward

The 2026 data is encouraging: of the students who took the Class 10 second board exam to improve, 59.95% raised their score, and 52.40% of compartment candidates cleared it. The system is built to give you a genuine second run, not a token one.

After the result: verification and re-evaluation

If you believe a paper was under-marked, CBSE runs a three-step process, and the order is fixed.

- Scanned copy of the answer book.** You must apply for this first. You cannot skip to verification. Compare it against the official marking scheme.
- Verification of marks.** The Board checks that all answers were evaluated and that totals were added correctly. It does not re-judge answers.
- Re-evaluation.** One or more full questions are re-checked. Re-evaluation is done for the whole question, and only for theory.

Two cautions. First, marks can go down as well as up — a drop of even one mark is implemented, so apply only where you have a genuine reason. Second, the outcome is final; there is no further appeal. Fees were revised for 2026 and differ by class, so always read the current notice on cbse.gov.in before applying.

The post-result timeline, based on 2026

Exact dates move each year, but the sequence is stable. Plan around the sequence.

Stage	When (2026 pattern)	What you do
Result declared	Class 12: 13 May. Class 10: 15 April	Download from DigiLocker; check the marksheet
Compartment / improvement exam	Jul-Aug for Class 12; May for the Class 10 second exam	Apply through your school within the window
Scanned copy of answer book	A few weeks after the result	Apply first if you want verification
Verification and re-evaluation	After the scanned-copy window	Compare against the marking scheme before applying

SECTION 8

Tools

The revision tracker

Print this once per subject. The point is not beauty; it is that you can see, at a glance, which chapters are still cold. A chapter is 'done' only when you have summarised it and passed a self-test on it.

Chapter	Read once	Summarised	Self-test passed	Mock cleared
1.				
2.				
3.				
4.				
5.				
6.				
7.				
8.				

Keep a second sheet as your error log: date, subject, question, marks lost, and the reason — knowledge gap or presentation gap. In the final two weeks, the error log becomes your main revision material.

The sample-paper and PYQ system

The official Sample Question Papers and marking schemes for 2026-27 are already published. Used well, they are the highest-value resource you have. Used badly, they are just another PDF.

- **Read the marking scheme before the paper.** It shows how marks are split — where a step is worth one mark, where a keyword is required. This is how you learn to write for the examiner.
- **Do the SQP open-book first**, so you learn the paper's shape. Then do it closed-book and timed.
- **Then add previous-year questions by chapter.** Repeated topics across years are your highest-yield revision list.
- **Always self-mark against the official scheme** and log every lost mark. A paper you do not mark teaches you nothing.

A ten-week mock schedule

Week	What to sit	How to review
1	SQP, open-book, one section	Compare with the marking scheme
2	SQP, closed-book, full paper	Log every lost mark
3	PYQ full paper, timed	Identify repeated topics
4	Weak-subject full paper	Rebuild the failed chapters
5	Two full papers	Fix time allocation per section
6	Two full papers	Rehearse case-based answers
7	Two full papers	Write to the mark value
8	Two full papers	Simulate exam conditions fully
9	Two full papers	Revise from the error log
10	One light paper, then taper	Rest and protect sleep

The 25-question self-test

Answer these without looking anything up. They test whether you understand the exam itself, not just your subjects. The answers follow on the next page.

- 1 What is the pass mark in each CBSE subject?
- 2 How are Class 10 internal marks split into four blocks?
- 3 What percentage of the theory paper is competency-based?
- 4 Is there negative marking in CBSE board papers?
- 5 What is the theory/practical split for Class 12 Physics?
- 6 What is the theory/internal split for Class 12 Mathematics?
- 7 Can strong internal marks compensate for a weak Class 10 theory paper in 2027?
- 8 In a Class 12 practical subject, must you pass theory and practical separately?
- 9 How do you convert CGPA to an indicative percentage?
- 10 What grade range is A1?
- 11 How many subjects can a Class 10 student improve in the second board exam?
- 12 Which subjects can be improved in the Class 10 second exam?
- 13 How many chances does a compartment candidate get?
- 14 What is the first step in the re-evaluation process?
- 15 Can re-evaluation change marks downward?
- 16 What is the estimated exam start date for 2027, and why?
- 17 When is the 2027 date sheet expected?
- 18 What is the LOC, and why does it matter?
- 19 What is the exam reporting-to-finish time for a three-hour paper?
- 20 Which section of the Class 10 paper carries case-based questions?

- 21 Name one fast source of marks in Social Science.
- 22 What is the first rule of the 3:1 study rule?
- 23 What is the error log for?
- 24 When should you stop studying new topics?
- 25 What two documents should you confirm before the exam window?

Self-test answer key

- 1 33% in each subject (for Class 10, 33% aggregate with theory and internal combined).
- 2 Periodic assessment 5, multiple assessment 5, portfolio 5, subject enrichment 5.
- 3 About 50% (case-based, source-based, application MCQs), with about 20% objective and 30% short/long.
- 4 No. Attempt every objective question.
- 5 70 marks theory + 30 marks practical.
- 6 80 marks theory + 20 marks internal assessment.
- 7 Yes, for 2026-27. The separate 33% rule was withdrawn, so the aggregate rule applies.
- 8 Yes — 33% in theory and 33% in practical separately, plus 33% aggregate.
- 9 Add the grade points of your five best subjects, divide by 5, multiply by 9.5.
- 10 91 to 100 marks.
- 11 Up to three main subjects.
- 12 Science, Mathematics, Social Science and languages (theory only).
- 13 Three: July/August, then March/April next year, then July/August again.
- 14 Apply for the scanned copy of the evaluated answer book.
- 15 Yes — a decrease of even one mark is implemented.
- 16 Around 16 February 2027, the first Tuesday after 15 February, CBSE's stated planning rule.
- 17 Expected late October 2026, following the pattern of previous years.
- 18 The List of Candidates — the school's registration of you for the exam; without it you cannot sit.
- 19 10:30 am to 1:30 pm IST.
- 20 Section E (case-based / source-based questions).
- 21 The map-skill question (5 marks), which is pure preparation.
- 22 For every three hours of new study, spend one hour testing yourself.
- 23 A notebook of every mistake and its reason, revised in the final weeks.
- 24 Mid-January — Phase 3 is revision and full papers only.
- 25 Your admit card and the LOC / subject registration.

Common mistakes checklist

- Studying everything equally instead of weighting the 50% competency-based block.
- Ignoring internal assessment, then discovering you lost 8 marks you never had to.
- Reading textbooks in February instead of revising your own notes.
- Doing papers without a clock, then running out of time in the real exam.
- Leaving objective questions blank despite there being no negative marking.
- Writing long answers as one block instead of labelled points.
- Forgetting units and diagram labels — the cheapest marks to lose.
- Panic-checking social media for 'date sheet leaks' instead of watching cbse.gov.in.

Frequently asked questions

Will the 2027 board exam be harder?

The pattern is unchanged from 2025-26, and roughly half the paper is competency-based. It is not harder in content; it rewards application more than rote recall.

Does CBSE give an overall percentage?

No. The marksheet shows grades, not an aggregate percentage. For applications, convert CGPA to an indicative percentage using the 9.5 multiplier.

Is 90%+ realistic?

Yes — in 2026, 5.32% of Class 12 candidates scored 90% and above. It is competitive but clearly achievable with a plan and timed practice.

What if I fail one subject?

You are placed in the compartment category and get three chances to clear it. See Section 7.

Should Class 10 students take the second board exam?

Only if you want to improve, and you can take up to three main subjects. The better of your two scores counts.

Where do I get the real dates?

Only from cbse.gov.in and cbseacademic.nic.in. Ignore screenshots and forwarded messages.

Do internal marks count in Class 12?

Yes. Non-lab subjects carry 20 internal marks and lab subjects 30 practical marks. In practical subjects you must clear 33% in theory and practical separately.

Is there any benefit to the Class 10 second exam?

Yes, if you want to improve. Up to three main subjects, theory only, and the better of your two scores counts. In 2026, 59.95% of those who tried it improved.

What happens if I am absent for the main exam?

Attendance in the first exam is mandatory. Missing three or more subjects places you in the Essential Repeat category rather than the improvement route.

Can I change my subject combination now?

After the LOC is submitted, subject changes are restricted. Raise any change with your school immediately, before the window closes.

How many subjects do I need to pass?

Class 10: all five. Class 12: all five, with the separate theory/practical rule in practical subjects.

A one-page briefing for parents

Most exam-season friction at home comes from good intentions and unclear roles. This is what genuinely helps, and what quietly hurts.

Helps	Hurts
Keeping the LOC details and datesheet checked and visible	Comparing your child's pace with a neighbour's or a cousin's
Protecting sleep, meals and one rest evening a week	Turning the house silent and tense for three months
Asking 'what did you practise today?' instead of 'how much did you study?'	Buying another test series the week before the exam
Treating one bad mock as data, not as a verdict	Discussing results in front of relatives

If your child's sleep, appetite or mood changes sharply, take it as seriously as a weak subject and speak to the school counsellor or a doctor. A steady home is worth more than any extra coaching hour.

A final word

The board exam rewards three unglamorous things: coverage, practice and calm. You now have the rules, the plan, the subject checklists and the tools. Nothing left on that list requires luck.

Start today. Download your sample papers, build the tracker, and finish one untouched chapter this week. Do that, keep the error log, and sit the paper rested and rehearsed. That is the whole method, and it is entirely in your hands.

Sources and verification notes

This handbook was compiled on 2 October 2026 from the Central Board of Secondary Education's own materials, and from mainstream reporting of the Board's notifications where the original notice was not directly downloadable. Primary sources include:

- CBSE notification CBSE/CE/2-Board Examinations-X/2025 (25 June 2025): the two-board-examination policy for Class X.
- CBSE clarification 31/CBSE/CE/2-Board Examination-X/2026 (14 February 2026) and the draft scheme for two examinations.
- CBSE academic notification CBSE/Academic/AP&AD(PV)/2026 (21 September 2026): sample papers for 2026-27, no change to paper design or passing criteria.
- CBSE Class X and Class XII marks-distribution notices for 2025-26, and the Scheme of Examinations and Pass Criteria.
- CBSE press releases: Class XII results (13 May 2026), Class X results (15 April 2026), Class X second board exam results (18 July 2026).
- CBSE post-result guidance for students and parents (21 June 2026) and the Class X post-result notice (August 2026).
- Official websites: cbse.gov.in and cbseacademic.nic.in.

Where a figure is an estimate rather than a Board-published number — most importantly the expected 16 February 2027 start — it is labelled as expected on the page. Rules, dates and fees are revised by the Board from time to time; verify before you act. This is an independent publication and is not affiliated with the CBSE.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
LOC	List of Candidates — the school's registration of you for the exam
SQP	Sample Question Paper, released by CBSE with a matching marking scheme
CBQ	Competency-Based Question — case, source or application based
IA	Internal Assessment — marks awarded by your school during the year
CGPA	Cumulative Grade Point Average, from your best five subjects
Compartment	The second chance for a subject you did not clear
Essential Repeat	The category for students who cannot take the second exam
OSM	On-Screen Marking — CBSE's digital evaluation of answer books